



EATERS

By Prabhu Chawla

Cricket is a gentleman's game where fielders are known to applaud an opposing batsman's century or an exquisite shot. But last week, when BJP general secretary Arun Jaitley, ensconced on the balcony at Lord's, was seen on TV applauding a boundary by Kevin Pietersen in the India-England T20 match, his detractors back home were busy circulating text messages. One read: "He led his party to a debacle, and now he is a witness to the defeat of India". Jaitley, a hardcore cricket buff, was in London with his family on holiday while his party back home was imploding, just like the Indian team. At the same time, his colleague Ravi Shankar Prasad was in New York while another spokesman, Prakash Javadekar, was holidaying in Europe. It was clearly a good time to escape from the heat of Delhi and, possibly, the heat being generated by the internal wars that have reduced the BJP to a caricature of its disciplined "party with a difference" image and raised embarrassing questions about its future. Just as success has many fathers and failure none, the BJP was left scrambling for scapegoats to blame for the party's most debilitating performance since its phenomenal rise began exactly over two decades ago. Suddenly letter writing became a primary talent of party leaders and the purple prose came with a premium. Individuals who formed the Losers Team started blaming ideology, or lack of it, for the loss. And those who had won decisively discovered new infirmities in the leadership. Appropriately enough, the first shot was fired by ex-soldier and veteran Jaswant Singh, considered to be one of the

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Photo Montage by PRASHANT CHOWDHURY. Photographs by SIPRA DAS, VASANT NEDI, GREENSING V

UP to a new low. A major overhaul is due if the party is to bounce back